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California governor Gavin Newsom signs $2.5 billion wildfire relief package amid devastating blazes

January 24, 2025 | Times of India, The (Mumbai, India)
Author: TOI World Desk | Section: US | 588 Words
OpenURL Link

California Governor Gavin Newsom has signed a $2.5 billion relief package to help the Los Angeles area recover from recent deadly wildfires. The package, approved with bipartisan support by the state Legislature, includes funds for emergency disaster response efforts, streamlining approvals for rebuilding homes, and supporting school districts in rebuilding facilities.

The aid was approved a day before President Donald Trump's scheduled visit to California to assess the damage from the blazes. Despite Trump's suggestion that federal wildfire relief should come with conditions, congressional Republicans representing the state have pushed back on the idea.

Newsom initially called lawmakers into a special session in November to prepare for legal battles against Trump's administration. However, after major fires broke out around Los Angeles this month, the governor shifted focus to prioritise fire relief funding under pressure from Republican state lawmakers.

Republican state Sen. Kelly Seyarto criticised Newsom for not issuing the fire relief funding on his own but ultimately supported the bills. He called for better collaboration between Democrats and Republicans in crafting legislation for fire response and prevention funding in the future. "We need a plan from all of us to make sure this doesn't happen again," he said.

The state Senate also approved $25 million to defend the state against legal challenges by the federal government and another $25 million for legal groups to defend immigrants facing possible deportation and other threats. The state Assembly would still need to pass these bills before they can reach Newsom's desk.

The largest of the recent Southern California blazes, which ignited on January 7, ripped through the Pacific Palisades neighborhood in Los Angeles, killing 11 people. The Eaton Fire, which broke out the same day near Altadena, has killed 17 people. The region is also now battling the Hughes Fire, which ignited Wednesday north of Los Angeles, spread more than 15 square miles (39 square kilometers), and led to evacuation orders or warnings for more than 50,000 people.

"This is about distilling a sense of hopefulness," Newsom said at a news conference in Pasadena, a city recovering from one of the destructive fires that ignited earlier this month.

State Senate President Pro Tempore Mike McGuire, a Democrat representing the North Coast, said the fires have been "nothing short of devastating." "But we promise we have your back, and we're going to get through this," he said before Newsom signed the aid into law.

Newsom's administration expects the state to be reimbursed by the federal government for the disaster relief funding. The governor also announced a commitment by 270 state-chartered banks, credit unions, and lenders to provide mortgage relief to homeowners impacted by fires in Los Angeles and Ventura counties.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat from Encino and chair of the chamber's special session budget committee, emphasized that the funding passed by the Legislature on Thursday is "the first of many steps" lawmakers will take to support wildfire survivors and protect communities from future blazes.

The Southern California region is still burning but some progress has been made to contain the blazes. Firefighters made progress containing the Hughes Fire near Castaic Lake, north of Los Angeles, with 25% containment by

Thursday.

Evacuation orders for tens of thousands were lifted, but new fires erupted in Southern California, including in San Diego and Ventura counties. Strong winds and dry conditions posed ongoing challenges, though rain expected this weekend may provide relief. Meanwhile, the Palisades and Eaton fires, which have burned for weeks, are nearing full containment

Source- (The Times of India)

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  World Desk, T. (2025, January 24). California governor Gavin Newsom signs $2.5 billion wildfire relief package amid devastating blazes. *Times of India, The (Mumbai, India)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19E4CD096BE3B7C0.